



BEHIND THE
BUMRAH
WORKLOAD
CONVERSATION

RESILIENCE IN TRANSITION

Shubman Gill's young side **defied doubts**, adapting under pressure to secure a 2-2 series draw in England.

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The sun shone bright that afternoon. The Indian team was yet to arrive at Lord's for its training session. Even before the security personnel could take up their usual positions, a solitary figure walked towards the centre wicket, all alone.

For the next 22-odd minutes, he wandered around the square, touched the grass, bowed down and inspected the surface. There were no support staff around him, no photographers to capture the moment, and by the time the travelling media contingent realised what was happening, he had left.

Nobody knew why Shubman Gill had come alone. The India captain ensured it remained a well-kept secret.

The five-Test series was evenly poised at that stage, with both India and England having won one match each. India, fresh from a one-sided win in Birmingham, had the chance to extend its lead. For Gill, on his

maiden tour of England as captain, this was the biggest challenge yet.

India eventually suffered a narrow defeat at Lord's. Still, Gill's quiet reconnaissance — something he repeated throughout the series — paid off as the team came from behind and levelled the series 2-2 at The Oval, a result few had predicted when the squad landed in England in June.

It was a walk into the unknown for Gill and his young Indian side, in transition after the exits of Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma. Doubts persisted over whether there was enough firepower without the two stalwarts, and pundits had written the team off before a ball was bowled. But coach Gautam Gambhir and Gill shut out the noise, focussing solely on their shared goal.

That mindset proved effective.

Back in the late 1990s and early 2000s, the famed Australian team led by Steve Waugh was renowned for playing mind games with opponents. The Indian team seemed to take a leaf out of that book, refusing to acknowledge the success of the Bazball model and keeping England guessing over its team combination.

Even though it was decided that Jasprit Bumrah would play only three matches due to workload management, the Indian camp maintained the suspense over which games he would feature in. In the final Test at The Oval, no one knew until the last minute whether Bumrah would play or be rested.

England, sticking to its tradition of naming the XI a couple of days before a match, had no clear read on India's likely side. That uncertainty unsettled England's planning and, before a ball was bowled, handed India a psychological edge.

While India managed matters shrewdly off the pitch, there were teething troubles.

At Leeds, despite posting a tall total, the team lost as England chased down 371. **For much of the final session, Gill looked under pressure, with Bumrah, K. L. Rahul and Rishabh Pant stepping in with suggestions.**

With Gill taking a back seat, Bumrah and Pant reshuffled the bowlers and made key calls, raising questions over whether the young captain was ready for the role.

But as the series wore on, Gill